B2 Vocabulary

Word formation: prefixes and suffixes

Build families of words from one root and choose the right form for nouns, verbs, adjectives and opposites.

Knowing one word can give you four or five more. Suffixes change the word class (*decide → decision*), and prefixes usually change the meaning (*possible → impossible*). Word-formation tasks are common in B2 exams.

To make	Common endings or beginnings	Examples
Nouns	-tion, -ment, -ness, -ity, -ance	*inform → information, develop → development, kind → kindness*
Adjectives	-ful, -less, -ous, -able, -ive	*care → careful / careless, danger → dangerous, create → creative*
Verbs	-ise / -ize, -en, en-	*modern → modernise, wide → widen, courage → encourage*
Adverbs	-ly	*careful → carefully, happy → happily*
Opposites	un-, in-, im-, ir-, il-, dis-	*unhappy, incorrect, impossible, irregular, illegal, disagree*

Look at the gap. After *a / the* you need a noun; after *very* or before a noun, an adjective; next to a verb, often an adverb. Then check whether the sentence needs a negative meaning.

Common mistakes. Spelling changes: *happy → happiness* (y becomes i), *argue → argument* (lose the e). And the negative prefix depends on the word: *im-* before p and m (*impolite*), *il-* before l (*illogical*), *ir-* before r (*irresponsible*).

Practice

Use the word in brackets in the correct form.

1. The ___ of the new road took three years. (construct)
2. It was very ___ of you to leave the door open. (care)
3. She spoke so ___ that everyone agreed with her. (convince)
4. Parking here is ___ ; you'll get a fine. (legal)
5. We need to ___ the road to reduce traffic. (wide)

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. construction
2. careless
3. convincingly
4. illegal
5. widen